

Dial-up networking

Q. In the Quickstart section of Digit, September 2002, you demonstrated how to connect to another computer through a dial-up connection. Is it possible to connect to a computer in another country too? My husband wants to connect to my system in India and he is in the UAE. Will the calls be charged by ISD rates? Please let me know.

Abha

Via e-mail

A The Quickstart primarily dealt with connections established over a telephone line and though connections can be established across the globe, one of you will have to call the other to establish them, inviting international call rates. An alternative is to set up a dedicated point-to-point connection between your computers, but the costs of such an operation for home users is too prohibitive to even discuss. So if you need to transfer files to each other, the best solution is to use instant messengers such as MSN Messenger (www.msn.com) or Yahoo! Messenger (www.yahoo.com). The Windows XP Messenger gives you far greater control over a remote computer and the file transfer application is also very user-friendly.

Post removal hard disk problems

Q. When I connect my 20 GB hard disk to a friend's PC, both our computers work fine. But after I disconnect my hard disk, my friend's machine shows two CD drives, one of which does not work. The system also slows down a lot. Please give us a solution for this.

Taral B. Khasiya

Via e-mail

A Unfortunately, you haven't mentioned your system configuration, so based on your information, do the following. Reboot the PC and enter the BIOS by pressing [Del] or the appropriate key for your BIOS. In Standard CMOS Setup, set the drive type for all the IDE drives to Auto. Then go back to the main menu and enter Integrated Peripherals. Change the PIO and UDMA modes to Auto. Now save your settings and reboot. It's also a good idea to examine the IDE cables to see if they're properly connected. The long end should go to the motherboard, while the two connections close by on the other end go to the devices. Finally, download the latest drivers for your motherboard's chipset. If you don't know the motherboard's manu-

Buying a new computer

Q. I'm contemplating buying a new P4-based machine, primarily for entertainment purposes. But after going through some comparisons, I have a few doubts:

1. Is it true that with a GeForce2, 3 or 4-based AGP card, I can play the latest as well as older games?

2. If an AGP card is marked OpenGL/DirectX compatible, does it mean that it has both capabilities and can play both types of games?

3. What types of CD formats are supported by a DVD-ROM drive? Is it also capable of writing CDs?

4. Is it true that in order to play games I must have the same type of RAM for my processor and AGP card?

Vishal Arora

Delhi

A Let's tackle your questions point by point:

1. Yes, you will be well equipped to play new and old games with any of these cards, particularly the GeForce4 Ti 4600 or the ATi Radeon 9700. Please note that any new card is backward compat-

ible, that is, it will be capable of running older games. However, the latest card is the latest only till a new game pushes the graphics higher.

2. Yes, any AGP card marked thus will support both kinds of games and the newer the Direct3D/OpenGL version

supported, the better. The newest cards are DirectX 9 and OpenGL 1.3 compatible.

3. The CD formats supported by DVD drives vary according to the manufacturer, but generally, they support CD-ROM, CD-ROM XA, CD-R, CD-RW, Photo-CD, Video-CD, Multi-

Session, CD TEXT and CD Extra. A DVD-ROM drive, as its name suggests, is only able to read DVDs and CDs. DVD R/RW drives are able to write DVDs and CDs, but again, the exact formats supported depend on the manufacturer and the model. Check the specifications of the writer before you buy one.

4. The RAM types of your system and your AGP display controller have absolutely nothing to do with each other and do not affect one another in any way.



facturer, you can go to www.motherboards.org to identify the board type.

Problem with free memory

Q. I have a 466 MHz Celeron CPU, Intel 815 motherboard, a 40 GB hard drive, 52x CD-ROM, 320 MB RAM and onboard graphics with 1 MB of shared memory. When I run and then close a lot of programs, Windows' System Monitor shows 244 MB of RAM utilised. Is this reading harmless or do I have to do something about it? Please help.

Raviteja

Via e-mail

A Since you have 320 MB of memory, you should not have any problems with low resources for most applications. The reason why System Monitor shows this high reading is because it probably takes some time to refresh its information or because the memory used by these programs is not

completely de-allocated until some other program requests it. Check to see that too many programs aren't loading themselves during startup—ensure that your System Tray is not too filled with running programs. To free up more RAM, remove unnecessary programs from the Startup program group in your Start menu. Anyway, as long as you don't get any 'Low virtual memory' messages—which, considering your RAM, is highly unlikely—you have nothing to worry about.

Virus problems

Q. I have two computers running Windows 98, which are connected to each other through a LAN card. The main computer is plagued with the Win32.Worm.datom virus and gives the following error messages: 'Cannot find file MSVXD.EXE. Could not load or run MSVXD.EXE specified in the WIN.INI file.' Is there any software to remove this virus?